

Anika Mahajan

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Education

University of Colorado, Boulder - ATLAS Institute

Aug 2024 –

PhD in Creative Technology and Design

University of California, Santa Cruz

Sept 2019 – June 2023

Bachelor of Science in Computer Science: Computer Game Design

- Minors: Astrophysics and Computer Science
- GPA: 3.89

Research Experience

Center for Transformational Play, Carnegie Mellon

Jan 2024 – Jun 2024

Research Assistant

- Gathering and organizing sources for an IGE proposal
- Managing and updating the bibliography, ensuring accuracy and completeness

ALT Games Lab, UCSC

Oct 2020 – Oct 2024

Undergraduate Research Assistant

- Researching how failure design affects player challenge and experience
- Assisting with observations and qualitative data analysis to uncover design recommendations
- Conducting an in-depth literature review regarding gamification, self-care, and quantified self

Creative Coding Lab, UCSC

Jan 2021 – Apr 2021

Undergraduate Research Assistant

- Refactoring a data visualization web application for cosmological simulation data

Publications

Marjorie Ann Cuervo, **Anika Mahajan**, Josh Mao, and Edward Melcer. (2023). "[Try Again?: A Macro-Level Taxonomy of the Challenge and Failure Process in Games](#)". In 2023 IEEE Conference on Games (CoG). IEEE.

Marjorie Ann Cuervo, **Anika Mahajan**, and Edward Melcer. (2021). "[Die-r Consequences: Player Experience and the Design of Failure through Respawn Mechanics](#)". In 2021 IEEE Conference on Games (CoG). IEEE.

Work Experience

Lawrence Livermore National Laboratory, Livermore, CA

Computing Scholar Intern

July - Sept 2022

- Researching and testing new technologies to connect Java and Python at runtime to modernize their image processing

Computing Scholar Intern

June - Sept 2021

- Creating a complete Application Program Interface (API) in Java with full documentation and an example class for the Status Verifier to improve automated testing and increase availability

Computing Scholar Intern

June - Sept 2020

- Redesigning the Status Verifier, a mission critical application, in Java for the National Ignition Facility based on the Model-View-Controller design pattern

UCSC Campus Natural Reserve, Santa Cruz, CA

Automated Camera Trap Processing Internship

Oct - Dec 2023

- Creating an application to automatically detect animal presence within camera trap photos to speed processing of hundreds of camera trap images.

Honors

Cum Laude, UCSC

2023

Highest Honors in the Major, UCSC

2023

Phi Beta Kappa, Phi Beta Kappa Upsilon Chapter at UCSC

2023

Koret Scholar, Koret Foundation

2022

Presentations and Workshops

OurCS: Women in Tech Workshop, Carnegie Mellon

Oct 2022

- 3 day research-focused workshop for undergraduates ending with a research poster presentation

Fail and Retry: A Taxonomy of Player Challenge and Failure in Virtual Reality Games, UCSC

May 2022

- Poster presentation describing the flow and process of failure in games at Koret Slam 2022

Skills

Programming: Java, Python, C and Embedded C, C++, C#, HTML, CSS, JavaScript

Libraries and Frameworks: React, p5.js, Phaser, Unity

Research: Literature Review, Data Analysis, Qualitative Coding

Interpersonal: Collaboration, Adaptability, Problem-Solving, Mindfulness

Organizations

Slug Shelter

Jan 2021 – Sept 2021

- Researching, planning, and networking to start a shelter for college-aged students experiencing homelessness in Santa Cruz. ([News Article](#))

Girls Who Code

Aug 2016 – Present

- Member of College Loop Club at UCSC

- Treasurer of Foothill High School GWC Club

- Alumna of Summer Immersion Program 2017 at Pivotal